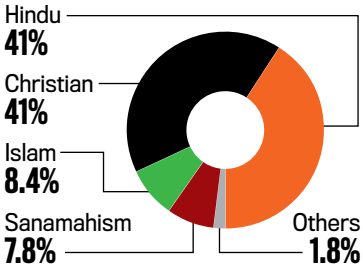
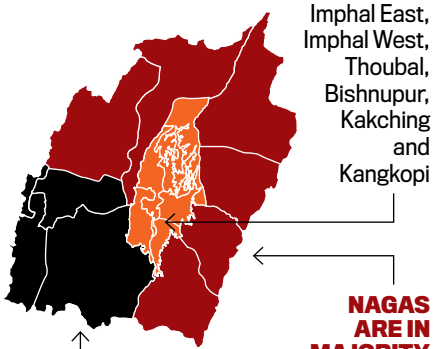
RELIGIOUS DIVIDE



Per cent of population

GEOGRAPHICAL DIVIDE



MEITEI ARE IN MAJORITY
Imphal East, Imphal West, Thoubal, Bishnupur, Kakching and Kangkopi

NAGAS ARE IN MAJORITY
Ukhrul, Kamjong, Tengnoupal, Senapati, Tamenglong and Chandel

KUKIS ARE IN MAJORITY
Churachandpur, Jiribam, Noney and Pherzwal

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

of the entire state. Tribal groups point out that the Meitei community, besides its sprinkling of Brahmins, is already classified under Scheduled Castes (SCs) or Other Backward Classes (OBCs). They fear, not without reason, that tribal status is only a Trojan horse to help open the gates to the hills for the Meiteis.

That's why the Biren Singh government's drive against 'illegal encroachers' from forest areas in the hills became a trigger for the current Meitei-Kuki strife. The eviction drive in the K. Songjang village in Churachandpur on February 23—given deeper legal gravity by the destruction of large tracts of poppy cultivation in the hills—was a tipping point for the tribals. In November 2022, a forest department notification derecognised 38 villages in the Churachandpur and Noney districts, claiming they fell within the Churachandpur-Khoupum protected forest. "Around 19 per cent of Manipur's area is reserve forests and we are evicting illegal encroachments there," Biren Singh had said then. The move was also allegedly aimed at freeing the state from the drug menace. In several hill areas, villagers illegally cultivate poppy for extra income, and narcotics smuggling is rampant through the porous border with Myanmar.

The twin accusations of being 'illegal' encroachers and drug smugglers, however, are seen by the tribals as a form of official ingress into their territory by a Meitei-dominated regime. Since 2017, when the BJP first came to power, most villages affected by evictions from reserved forests have been Kuki. Many social observers naturally see racial profiling here, even if government officials insist similar eviction drives were conducted in the Imphal valley too.

Kuki leaders allege even legitimate residents have been evicted and their churches razed. They also claim the regime declared the Churachandpur-Khoupum Scheduled Hill Area a protected forest without proper notification. Under Article 371C of the Constitution, specifically applicable to Manipur, they say the state government cannot make amendments to the scope of the Indian Forest Act, 1927. In an April 12 letter to state environment minister Biswajit Singh, Haokip questioned a revenue and forest survey in Churachandpur-Khoupum—in line with the allegation by Kuki outfits that the government's "illegal" modification of norms is a ploy to grab tribal land.

Meitei organisations, in turn, allege that "illegal immigrants from Myanmar, Nepal and Bangladesh" are marginalising "the indigenous people of Manipur". They have demanded the implementation of the National Register of Citizens and the setting up of a population commission. They claim there has been unnatural population growth in the hills, with a decadal growth rate of 40 per cent as against 16 per cent in the valley, as per the 2011 Census. Kukis have been attacked as "immigrants" or "foreigners", the suggestion being they are migrants from Myanmar. That sentiment intensified when Myanmarese refugees from the Kuki-Chin-Zomi-Mizo ethnic continuum, sharing origins with the hill tribes of Manipur, Mizoram and Nagaland, fled to these states following the unrest in that country. Meitei groups claim new villages are emerging in reserved forest lands, with a concomitant spread of poppy.

WHILE KUKIS SAY THERE IS A PLOY TO GRAB THEIR LAND, MEITEIS OFTEN ACCUSE THEM OF BEING OUTSIDERS

The stage was set for fire, and a lit match duly appeared. On March 10, violence erupted in Kangpokpi town during one of the rallies called in the hills by the newly formed Indigenous Tribal Leaders Forum (ITLF) to protest the evictions. The next day, the government withdrew from the Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement with three tribal militant outfits—the Kuki National Army (KNA), Zomi Revolutionary Army (ZRA) and Kuki Revolutionary Army (KRA)—saying they were supporting Myanmarese immigrants and encouraging poppy cultivation. On April 28, in Churachandpur, a Kuki-dominated area 65 km south of Imphal, a mob attacked an open gym that was to be inaugurated by the CM next day—and the flames spread.

Biren Singh's return to power last year was attributed partly to his "Go to Hills" policy, aimed at taking welfare benefits to the tribals. Now, he is at the receiving end of tribal outrage, and is also seen to have allowed a law-and-order crisis that saw 1,041 guns being looted (only 214 were recovered) and insurgents fanning the anarchy. ■